



A STILL FROM SHAAP SHIRI

## THEATRE

## Playing it RIGHT

With Bengali the fifth most-spoken language in Bangalore, it is not surprising that there are quite a few cultural festivals aimed at the Bengali diaspora. Moitree 2009 is a theatre festival showcasing plays from West Bengal as well as Bangalore. Organised for the second time by MukhOsh, the only Bangla theatre company in Bangalore, and supported by the Government of West Bengal, three groups from Kolkata will bring their plays to the festival. Ensemble brings Mahesh Elkunchwar's *Sonata* in English, Gandhar comes with the Bangla play *Kachher Manush* and Sansriti unveils *Surya Pora Chhai*. MukhOsh will perform *Shaap Shiri*, and Anya Poshaak, a new theatre group from Bangalore will perform *Lathi*. The plays span human relationships, tragedies and social issues. From May 29 at Bangalore's Ranga Shankara.

by **Nirmala Ravindran**

## DANCE FESTIVAL

## Steps to Revival

Traditional dance forms have always evolved from temples and flourished under royal patronage. With the concept dwindling, art forms like Krishnanattam have taken a beating. In 1654, Prince Manvedan of Kozhikode scripted and bequeathed a unique performing art to the cultural stream of Kerala that culminated in the form of the world-renowned Kathakali. In 1958, as the dance form struggled to cope with the changing socio-political scenario, it was taken over by the Guruvayoor Devaswom. Till then, this art form had been confined to the city of Kozhikode alone.

This year, Delhi will witness a Krishnanattam performance at the Uttara Guruvayurappan temple till May 18. The story of Lord Krishna will be presented in eight episodes,

starting from his incarnation (avatharam), to ascension and salvation (swargarohanam).

Though Kathakali has received much patronage and attention from the state Government, Krishnanattam, which is the originator of Kathakali, is in the throes of extinction. "There are few families in Kerala who are committed to carrying on this tradition. What is needed is sustained financial help to the children of these artistes who are either dancers or musicians," says Deepti Omcherry Bhalla, a Mohiniattam dancer. It has also been seen that Krishnanattam dancers imitate Kathakali which in turn is diluting the art form. It is not a happy outcome and one can only hope the original forms don't get wiped out.

by **S. Sahaya Ranjit**

## DANCE

## Fine Moves

Coming from a non-dancing background and tutored by gurus like Bharti Gupta and Aditi

Mangaldas, Kathak dancer

Rashmi Uppal has imbibed the finer nuances of the dance form. On May 20, watch her perform Svabhav—Expressions in Love.

She will depict the various moods of the *nayika*, be it bold or repentant, one of annoyance or

that of the longing lover. Traditional compositions are juxtaposed with the poetry of Mahadevi Varma, Dharamveer Bharti and Jayshankar Prasad to the music composed by Vidya Shah. Experience a gamut of emotions. In Delhi at the India Habitat Centre.

